7.15 The hillfort 'Zamczysko' ('The Burgstall'), Poland

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Location and surroundings

The hillfort called 'Zamczysko' ('The Burgstall') is located in the Kampinos National Park, which is key to preserving and protecting it. The Park was established in 1959, in order to protect the unique complex of inland dunes interspersed with marshes, its fauna and flora, as well as natural and cultural landscape. The variety of habitats, from very wet to very dry, ensures a great diversity of plants, fungi and lichens. Together with its buffer zone, the Park is also an important refuge for more than 5,000 animal species, 250 of which are protected.

Much of the Park (about 75%) is covered by forest. Strict protection areas have also been established within its territory, and about 12% of the Park area is left entirely to nature, allowing ecological processes to take their course. The hillfort is located within the Zamczysko Strict Protection Area (Fig.75). In 2000, the Kampinos National Park was declared a UNESCO Biosphere Reserve, and in 2004 it became a part of the 'Puszcza Kampinoska' Natura 2000 site. Kampinos is the second largest national park in the country (385 km^2). Its location close to Warsaw, Poland's growing capital, poses many threats to nature and cultural heritage. Risks include construction investments within the buffer zone, lowering of the groundwater table, as well as increased waste and fire hazard. The proximity of the major city also means excessive wilderness penetration by people and their pets, as Kampinos is a very popular walking destination for Varsovians. Hiking and biking trails are available near the hillfort, and the site area is open to visitors.

Figure 75: The hillfort called 'Zamczysko' within the Zamczysko Strict Protection Area in the Kampinos National Park, view from the walking trail, condition as at November 2022. (National Institute of Cultural Heritage, Agnieszka Makowska)

Reasons for assessment

The hillfort was entered to the register of monuments in 1965 (registry number: C-54). Since the 1985 it also has been listed in the National Inventory of Archaeological Sites (AZP 55-62/11). For its protection, however, its location within the Zamczysko Strict Protection Area is most beneficial. This is a passive form of natural world conservation, where a designated area is left entirely to nature, allowing ecological processes to take their course (Fig.76). This area of the Park is managed by the Director of the Kampinos National Park, appointed by the minister responsible for the environment. He acts under the provisions of the Act of 16 April 2004 on Nature Conservation. In areas listed in the register of monuments, any planned change requires the Voivodship Monuments Preservation Officer (VMPO) approval.

At the end of 2009, the hillfort was under evaluation as part of the project for the verification of all registered archaeological sites in Poland, conducted by National Institute of Cultural Heritage (NICH). A further assessment took place in 2015 when the VMPO requested the NICH's opinion on the design of the new visitor infrastructure on the hillfort.

Description of the site

The hillfort is situated on the southern edge of the wooded dune embankment, with extensive marshes at its foot. An old-growth forest with rare tree species grows on the archaeological site and around. Zamczysko in the Kampinos is an example of a well-preserved medieval hillfort. The double ring of ramparts and two moats are still clearly visible. The earthwork is egg-shape and closed, it is a so-called ringfort. The natural landform was used in the construction. The marshes acted as a natural defence. It measures c.102 x 78 m. The inner rampart is about 5 m high, the outer one is much lower. A relatively small part of the hillfort has been excavated. Our knowledge of the site is therefore incomplete, but it is enough for us to understand that we are dealing with relics that are definitely worth protecting and preserving in situ for future generations. Archaeologists have been interested in the site since at least 1923, when Zofia Podkowińska carried out a surface survey of the area. In order to verify the hypothesised function and dating of the site, a trial excavation was carried out in 1980 by Jerzy Pyrgała. It covered a small fragment of the inner part of the hillfort, and slope of the rampart towards the northern moat. Traces of burnt layer, charcoal, lumps of worked clay with wood print were found. Research has revealed remains of a domical kiln built of clay around a wooden framework, and wooden fortifications of the ringfort. These include burnt beams and laths, arranged horizontally, forming a 5-metre-wide strip. Remnants of the crossed logs construction were also discovered during an archaeological rescue excavation in 2017, conducted by Mariusz Samborski. This research was carried out when constructing a platform, footbridges and stairs for visitors (Fig.76). Researchers have also found medieval knives, iron bow and fragments of Gothic bricks, possibly from the brick tower existing on the castle. The place inspires the imagination – folk tales say Queen Bona Sforza, wife of King Sigismund I the Old, hid gold and valuables in the tower.

Figure 76: The hillfort called 'Zamczysko', view of the ramparts and the moats, with fallen trees not removed as it is within the Nature Strict Protection Area, and view of the inner part from the platform for visitors as at November 2022. (National Institute of Cultural Heritage, Agnieszka Makowska)

Figure 77: The hillfort called 'Zamczysko', with marshes visible in the background, as at November 2022. (National Institute of Cultural Heritage, Agnieszka Makowska)

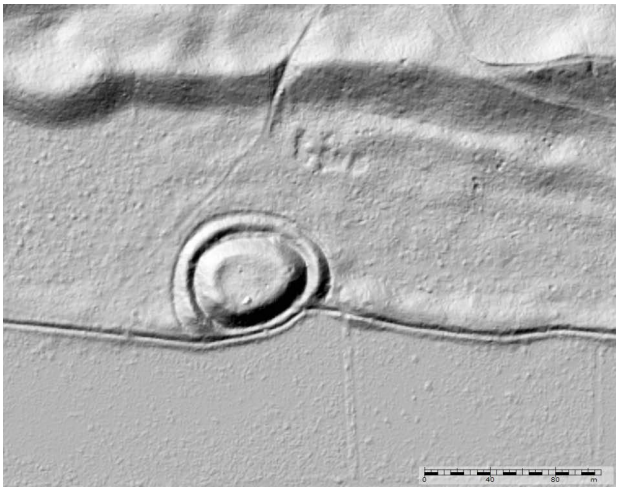

Figure 78: 'Zamczysko' - Digital Terrain Model, with a double ring of ramparts and two moats visible. (National Institute of Cultural Heritage, https://mapy.zabytek.gov.pl/nid/

Archaeological research, however, suggests that the castle was in use and was destroyed at a much earlier date. Dates given by archaeologists indicate the 12th to 14th century. There is no consensus among researchers as to whether the castle served as a refuge or was part of a larger fortification system. The more recent history of the site is linked to the period of World War Two. The area of the hillfort was one of the partisan bases. There was an unmarked grave on the rampart. In 2018, archaeologists from the Institute of National Remembrance carried out an archaeological investigation and exhumation of the young man buried there. The research only covered the tomb and did not provide any new information about the hillfort itself.

The current mode of a land use of the site is the result of a model collaboration between the Kampinos Park administration and Voivodship Monuments Preservation Officer, with expert support from the National Institute of Cultural Heritage. Due consideration was given to the need to protect both the archaeological and natural heritage The single platform is accessed by a staircase located on the western side of the hillfort. Made of composite planks, it has minimal impact on the existing cultural landscape, and does not require frequent repairs. The needs of tourism have also been taken into account. It makes it possible to enjoy the natural and archaeological heritage.

Assessing significance – methods and results

Based on the Polish monument protection law and criteria enumerated in the legal definition of an archaeological monument, we can articulate historical and scientific significance of the hillfort 'Zamczysko'. We are certainly dealing with the underground remains of the human activity, composed of cultural layers and works or traces contained in these layers. And, it was the state of preservation – the original strata and structures, largely preserved in situ – that had the greatest influence on the assessment of the monument's significance. They have considerable scientific potential. They are a time capsule, an almost complete record of how the site functioned in the past for future generations. This is what makes the place special. The same applies to the cultural landscape – all its components have been protected for centuries, including the preserved terrain form and the exposure of the monument and its surroundings. The hillfort is in close proximity to hiking and biking trails, and is a popular destination for trips from Warsaw. It is also of great educational significance. Using various criteria to assess the significance of the monument concerned, it is impossible to ignore the aesthetic and natural values considered important by the public perception. It is a beautiful green space for rest and reflection. This is a reflection on the difficult contemporary history and the events of World War Two, which also gives the place a symbolic value